

Psalms 68

Let God Arise

Let God arise, let his enemies be scattered
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Let God arise, let his enemies be scattered: let them also that hate him flee before him.*
- 2 *As smoke is driven away, so drive them away: as wax melteth before the fire, so let the wicked perish at the presence of God.*
- 3 *But let the righteous be glad; let them rejoice before God: yea, let them exceedingly rejoice.*
- 4 *Sing unto God, sing praises to his name: extol him that rideth upon the heavens by his name JAH, and rejoice before him.*
- 5 *A father of the fatherless, and a judge of the widows, is God in his holy habitation.*
- 6 *God setteth the solitary in families: he bringeth out those which are bound with chains: but the rebellious dwell in a dry land.*
- 7 *O God, when thou wentest forth before thy people, when thou didst march through the wilderness; Selah:*
- 8 *The earth shook, the heavens also dropped at the presence of God: even Sinai itself was moved at the presence of God, the God of Israel.*
- 9 *Thou, O God, didst send a plentiful rain, whereby thou didst confirm thine inheritance, when it was weary.*
- 10 *Thy congregation hath dwelt therein: thou, O God, hast prepared of thy goodness for the poor.*
- 11 *The Lord gave the word: great was the company of those that published it.*
- 12 *Kings of armies did flee apace: and she that tarried at home divided the spoil.*
- 13 *Though ye have lien among the pots, yet shall ye be as the wings of a dove covered with silver, and her feathers with yellow gold.*
- 14 *When the Almighty scattered kings in it, it was white as snow in Salmon.*
- 15 *The hill of God is as the hill of Bashan; an high hill as the hill of Bashan.*
- 16 *Why leap ye, ye high hills? this is the hill which God desireth to dwell in; yea, the LORD will dwell in it for ever.*
- 17 *The chariots of God are twenty thousand, even thousands of angels: the Lord is among them, as in Sinai, in the holy place.*
- 18 *Thou hast ascended on high, thou hast led captivity captive: thou hast received gifts for men; yea, for the rebellious also, that the LORD God might dwell among them.*
- 19 *Blessed be the Lord, who daily loadeth us with benefits, even the God of our salvation. Selah.*
- 20 *He that is our God is the God of salvation; and unto God the Lord belong the issues from death.*
- 21 *But God shall wound the head of his enemies, and the hairy scalp of such an one as goeth on still in his trespasses.*
- 22 *The Lord said, I will bring again from Bashan, I will bring my people again from the depths of the sea:*
- 23 *That thy foot may be dipped in the blood of thine enemies, and the tongue of thy dogs in the same.*
- 24 *They have seen thy goings, O God; even the goings of my God, my King, in the sanctuary.*
- 25 *The singers went before, the players on instruments followed after; among them were the damsels playing with timbrels.*
- 26 *Bless ye God in the congregations, even the Lord, from the fountain of Israel.*
- 27 *There is little Benjamin with their ruler, the princes of Judah and their council, the princes of Zebulun, and the princes of Naphtali.*
- 28 *Thy God hath commanded thy strength: strengthen, O God, that which thou hast wrought for us.*
- 29 *Because of thy temple at Jerusalem shall kings bring presents unto thee.*
- 30 *Rebuke the company of spearmen, the multitude of the bulls, with the calves of the people, till every one submit himself with pieces of silver: scatter thou the people that delight in war.*
- 31 *Princes shall come out of Egypt; Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God.*
- 32 *Sing unto God, ye kingdoms of the earth; O sing praises unto the Lord; Selah:*
- 33 *To him that rideth upon the heavens of heavens, which were of old; lo, he doth send out his voice, and that a mighty voice.*
- 34 *Ascribe ye strength unto God: his excellency is over Israel, and his strength is in the clouds.*
- 35 *O God, thou art terrible out of thy holy places: the God of Israel is he that giveth strength and power unto his people. Blessed be God.*

2 · CONTEXT

A grand processional and battle hymn of David, likely composed for the ark's journey (2 Sam 6) or a national festival, tracing God's power from the Exodus and wilderness march to His enthronement in Zion and reign over all kingdoms. It is quoted in Ephesians 4:8 concerning Christ's ascension and gift-giving to the church. Henry treats it as the Old Testament's great song of God as Warrior-King who defends the weak and receives tribute from the nations; MacArthur-style notes highlight its use of ancient triumphal procession imagery culminating in worldwide praise.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-6

The psalm opens as a battle cry (echoing Num 10:35) that quickly turns tender: "Let God arise, let his enemies be scattered... Sing unto God, sing praises to his name... A father of the fatherless, and a judge of the widows, is God... God setteth the solitary in families." The same God who scatters enemies champions the fatherless, widows, and lonely.

Verse 7-10

"O God, when thou wentest forth before thy people... the earth shook... the heavens also dropped at the presence of God... thou, O God, hast prepared of thy goodness for the poor." The Exodus and Sinai theophany are recalled as proof of God's protective, providing presence marching ahead of His people.

Verse 11-14

"The Lord gave the word: great was the company of those that published it. Kings of armies did flee apace... though ye have lien among the pots, yet shall ye be as the wings of a dove covered with silver." Victory is announced and celebrated even by those who seemed passive or lowly, transformed into glittering beauty.

Verse 15-18

"The hill of God is as the hill of Bashan... the chariots of God are twenty thousand... Thou hast ascended on high, thou hast led captivity captive: thou hast received gifts for men." God's dwelling surpasses Bashan's great mountains; His ascension with captured spoils anticipates Christ's ascension and gift-giving (Eph 4:8).

Verse 19-23

"Blessed be the Lord, who daily loadeth us with benefits, even the God of our salvation... God shall wound the head of his enemies." Ongoing, daily benefit-giving is coupled with certain judgment on persistent enemies—both mercy and justice belong to this King.

Verse 24-27

"They have seen thy goings, O God... the singers went before, the players on instruments followed after... Bless ye God in the congregations... There is little Benjamin with their ruler, the princes of Judah... Zebulun, and... Naphtali." A vivid worship procession names specific tribes taking their place in unified national praise.

Verse 28-31

"Strengthen, O God, that which thou hast wrought for us... kings shall bring presents unto thee... Princes shall come out of Egypt; Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God." Foreign nations, even former oppressors, are pictured submitting tribute to God—an early vision of Gentile inclusion in worship.

Verse 32-35

"Sing unto God, ye kingdoms of the earth... Ascribe ye strength unto God: his excellency is over Israel... The God of Israel is he that giveth strength and power unto his people. Blessed be God." The psalm closes with a global summons to praise the God whose strength both governs Israel and empowers His people for all that lies ahead.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God is Warrior and Father at once—scattering enemies while adopting orphans, marching through wilderness history while daily loading His people with benefits, ascending in triumph while inviting even former oppressor-nations to bring tribute. His strength is not only historical memory but present and future empowerment.

Application for life today.

Let the same God who scatters enemies shape how you pray for justice, while also remembering He is "father of the fatherless... judge of the widows"—strength and tenderness belong together in His character and should in yours. Recall specific "goings" of God in your own history as fuel for present praise. Trust that God still "daily loadeth us with benefits" even when the biggest battles feel unresolved, and expect His strength to be given, not just admired, for what's ahead.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does holding together God as Warrior (vv. 1, 21) and as Father of the fatherless (v. 5) shape your view of His character?

2. What specific "goings" of God in your past could you recall and retell as this procession psalm does?

3. Where do you need to trust that God will "daily" load you with benefits and give strength for a current battle?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).